'rubber stamp' for the government's decisions.

To add to the government's discomfiture, two former RBI Governors also spoke out against the erosion of RBI's autonomy.

Y.V. Reddy (RBI Governor, 2003–2008)[56] said, '*Credibility and public trust are of utmost need for a central bank*, not just as an issuer and custodian of currency, but also *to ensure financial stability in India's $2 trillion economy*… For a central bank, reputational risk is the worst risk, credibility is the worst risk. And if this is happening … I would say that it is a national problem now and it is not just a political issue.'[57]

On 10 January 2017, Bimal Jalan (RBI Governor, 1997–2003)[58] joined the debate and said the *autonomy of the RBI was sacrosanct*. 'The autonomy of the RBI – that is a very fundamental fact and we have to maintain it … on monetary policy issues, there should be consultation with the government. But *the government should agree with the RBI's final decision, even if it is difficult*.'[59]

It was not just former Governors of the RBI who were concerned about the RBI's loss of autonomy. Feeling 'humiliated' by events since the demonetization announcement, the United Forum of Reserve Bank Officers and Employees wrote an open letter to Governor Urjit Patel on 13 January 2017.

It stated, 'The autonomy and image of RBI has been dented beyond repair' due to mismanagement. 'An image of efficiency and independence that RBI assiduously built up over decades by the strenuous efforts of its staff and judicious policy making has gone into smithereens in no time. We feel extremely pained.'[60]

'The RBI has been discharging the role of currency management for over eight decades since 1935,' it continued, and 'the central bank does not need any assistance and the *interference from the finance ministry is absolutely unacceptable and deplorable*.'

Signed by four signatories[61] representing over 18,000 employees of the RBI, the letter urged the Governor to act: 'May we request that as the Governor of RBI, its highest functionary and protector of its